

THAMMASAT UNIVERSITY

AI Training Intelligence

Meta-Learning-Based Optimal Training Point Detection

Research Proposal

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Bachelor's Degree Program

20 September 2026

Abstract

AI Training Intelligence (ATI) is a proposed meta-learning framework for estimating a model's optimal training epoch from a partial training trajectory. The framework combines training and validation metrics, learning-rate information, gradient statistics, parameter updates, and temporal features. A meta-model predicts the epoch associated with the highest validation performance, while a controller determines whether training should continue. The proposed evaluation compares fixed-budget training, validation-based early stopping, learning-curve extrapolation, and resource-allocation methods. Performance will be assessed using epoch-prediction error, held-out task performance, computational cost, and transfer across datasets and architectures. The study is a research proposal: no empirical ATI results are reported, and the figures illustrate the planned analysis. The central question is whether predictive stopping can reduce net computation while keeping performance loss within a prespecified tolerance.

Keywords: meta-learning; learning curves; early stopping; training dynamics; generalization; computational efficiency.

1. Introduction

Selecting a training duration requires balancing computational cost against generalization performance. Continuing optimization may improve training performance without improving validation performance. This discrepancy motivates early stopping, although a widening training–validation gap alone does not establish that further training is harmful [1,2].

ATI treats training control as a supervised meta-learning problem. Completed training runs provide trajectories and retrospective labels; a second model learns to predict the validation-optimal epoch from a prefix of a new trajectory. The intended contribution is a predictive formulation and its evaluation across training regimes, rather than a replacement definition of early stopping.

The proposed study asks which training signals are informative, how early a useful prediction can be made, whether predictors transfer to unseen datasets or architectures, and whether the resulting savings exceed the overhead of telemetry and meta-model inference. It also examines whether temporal neural models provide measurable benefits over regression and tree-based predictors.

Figure 1 illustrates the distinction between continued training improvement and validation performance.

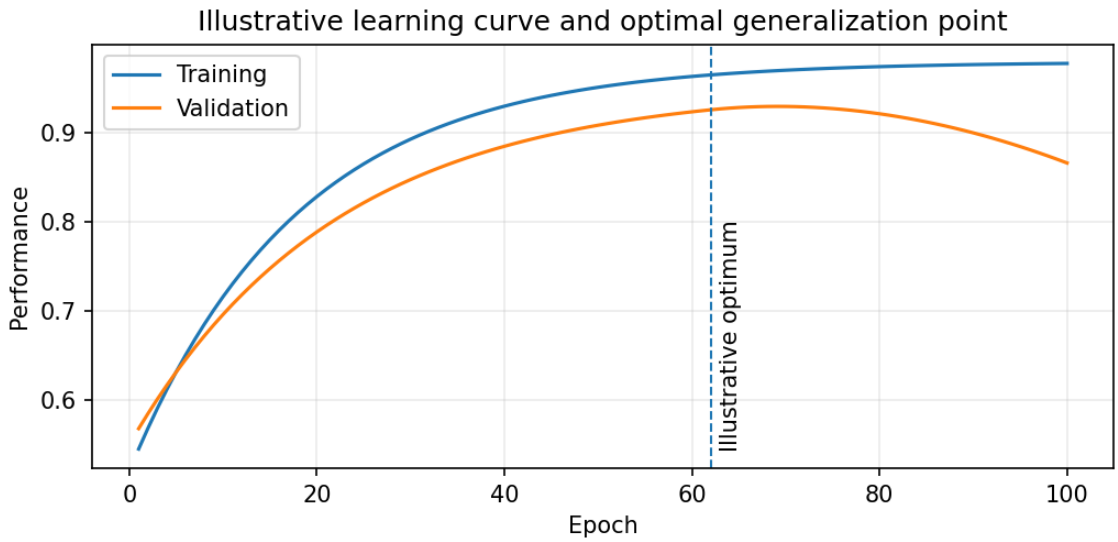


Figure 1. Conceptual training and validation performance. Illustrative; not experimental results.

2. Related Work

Validation-based early stopping applies a decision rule to observed validation behavior [1]. Hyperband allocates resources adaptively across configurations [3], and asynchronous successive halving supports parallel resource allocation [4]. These methods address related budget-allocation decisions but do not necessarily estimate a single run's future optimal epoch.

Learning-curve extrapolation predicts later performance from partial observations. Difficulty-aware extrapolation incorporates task difficulty into this prediction problem [5]. Activation-based early stopping studies transfer-sensitive training signals in a meta-learning setting [6]. ATI will be evaluated against these related approaches where their inputs and computational budgets can be matched. Its novelty and effectiveness remain hypotheses pending comparative experiments.

3. Problem Formulation

For a target run with budget T, let $X_{1:t}$ denote the telemetry observed through epoch t. For a higher-is-better validation metric P_{val}, the retrospective reference epoch is defined by:

$$E^* = \arg\max_{1 \le E \le T} P_{val}(E). \quad (1)$$

A predictor f estimates the reference epoch from a trajectory prefix:

$$\hat{E}^* = f(X_{1:t}), \quad t < T. \quad (2)$$

The reference epoch depends on the finite training budget and the validation sample; it is not an estimate of an unknowable population optimum. Ties require a fixed rule, such as choosing the earliest maximizing epoch. The evaluation will report whether each observed prefix occurs before or after E*, since an online controller cannot know this condition in advance. Selecting only prefixes that precede E* would overstate applicability.

For lower-is-better metrics, the optimization direction is reversed. A stable near-optimal interval may also be evaluated because individual validation maxima can be noisy. Model selection and controller design will use development data; the target task's final test data will remain separate from these decisions.

4. Proposed Method

4.1 Telemetry and temporal features

Candidate epoch-level inputs comprise training and validation loss, task metrics, learning rate, gradient norm, parameter-change magnitude, and the generalization gap. Task metrics may include precision, recall, F1, mAP, AUROC, MAE, or RMSE, as appropriate. Models need not expose every feature; availability must be recorded consistently.

$$X_t = [L_{tr}, L_{val}, P_{tr}, P_{val}, LR, \|g\|, \Delta W, G]_t. \quad (3)$$

Temporal features include first and second differences, rolling averages, and volatility. Derivatives represent the rate and stability of improvement but remain predictors rather than independent stopping criteria. Features and normalization statistics must depend only on the observed prefix. For higher-is-better metrics, the gap is defined as $G(E) = P_{train}(E) - P_{val}(E)$.

Figures 2–5 illustrate the proposed telemetry and temporal features.

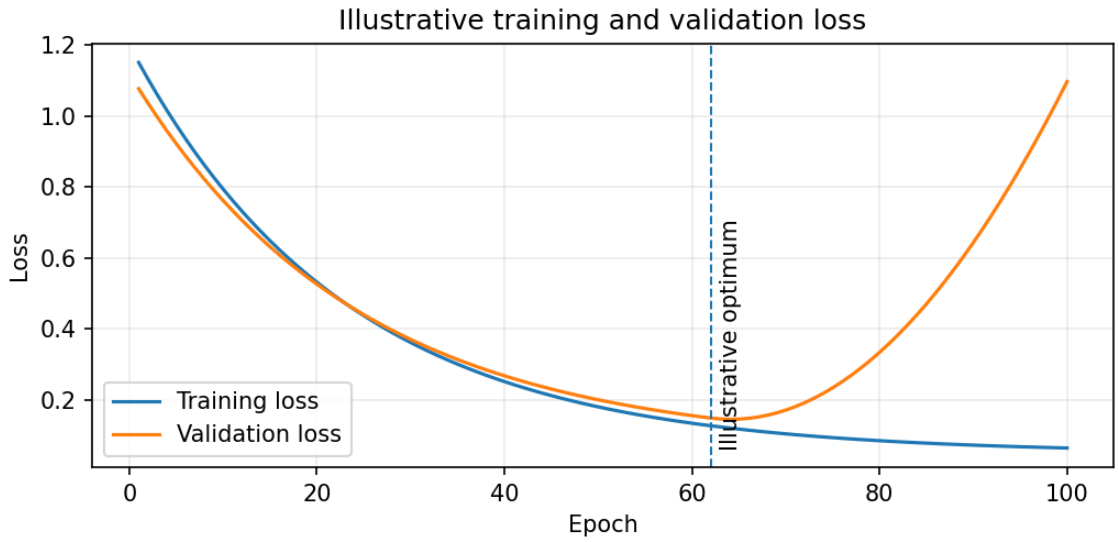


Figure 2. Training and validation loss trajectories. Illustrative; not experimental results.

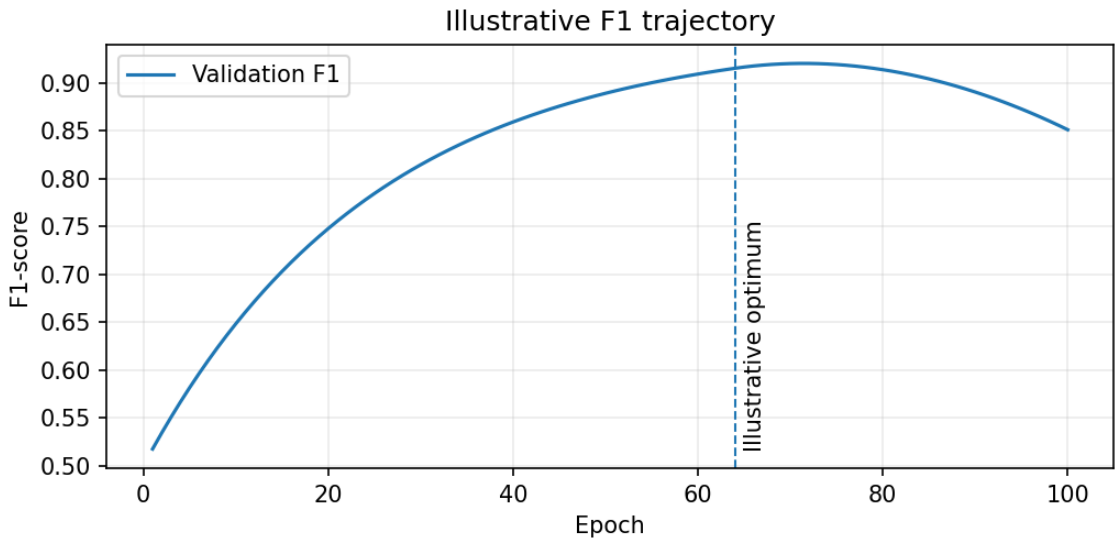


Figure 3. Validation F1 trajectory. Illustrative; not experimental results.

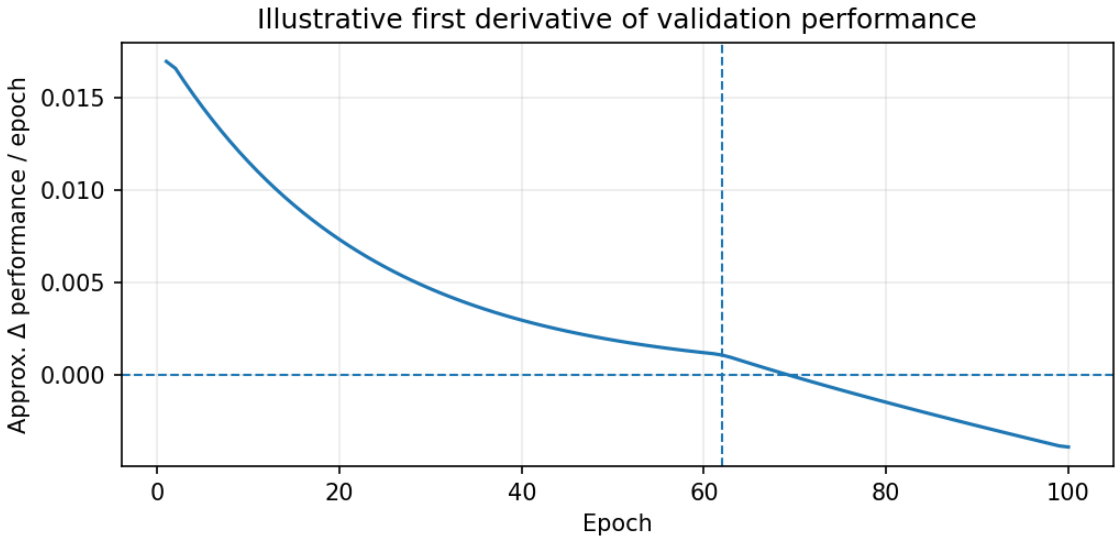


Figure 4. Rate of validation improvement. Illustrative; not experimental results.

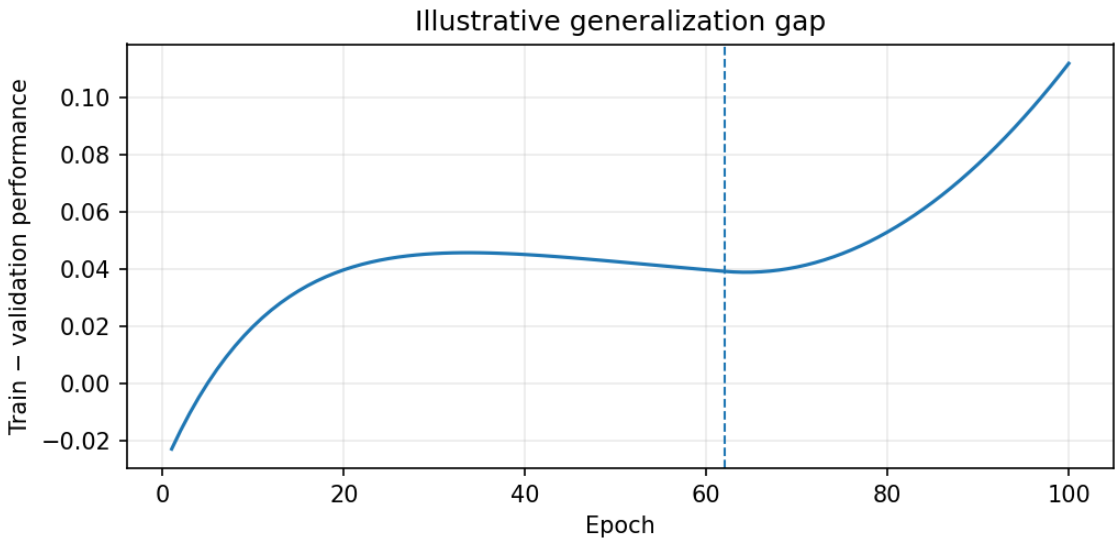


Figure 5. Generalization-gap trajectory. Illustrative; not experimental results.

4.2 Meta-dataset construction

The meta-dataset will consist of complete training runs spanning architecture families, datasets, learning rates, batch sizes, optimizers, random seeds, augmentation settings, and training budgets. Each run supplies prefix examples and a retrospective optimum. All prefixes from a run must remain in the same partition. Dataset- and architecture-disjoint evaluations will test transfer beyond closely related configurations.

Splitting will precede feature fitting and model selection. Runs sharing a dataset or a closely related configuration may remain statistically dependent; their grouping will be documented. Configuration files, seeds, telemetry, checkpoints, split identifiers, and feature definitions will be versioned to support reproduction.

4.3 Predictor families and controller

Initial predictors will include linear or polynomial regression, random forests, and gradient-boosted trees. Temporal candidates include LSTM/GRU networks, temporal convolutional networks, and Transformer encoders. Comparisons will account for predictive accuracy, inference overhead, and training cost. Increased model complexity is justified only if it improves the relevant cost–performance trade-off.

After offline evaluation, the predictor can be connected to a training controller that updates its estimate at fixed intervals. A conservative policy will continue training when uncertainty is high. A probabilistic extension may estimate $p(E^* \mid X_{1:t})$ or a near-optimal interval. Checkpoint retention is necessary when the predicted optimum lies before the current epoch.

Figure 6 summarizes the proposed flow from target-model telemetry to a stopping decision.

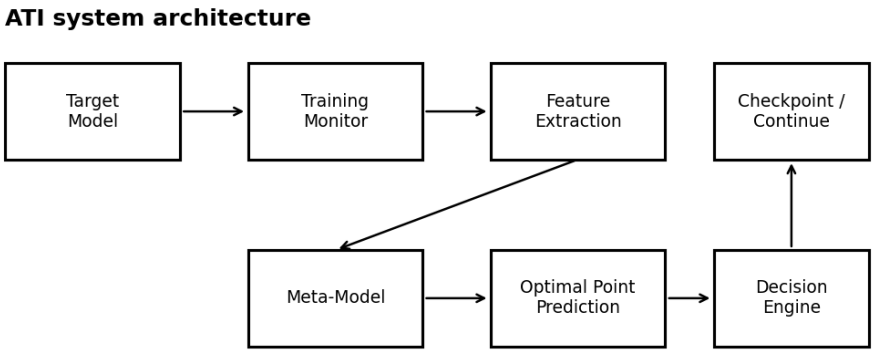


Figure 6. Proposed ATI architecture. Illustrative; not experimental results.

5. Experimental Design

5.1 Evaluation stages

The study comprises three stages: generation of complete target-model trajectories; fitting of meta-models on partial trajectories; and evaluation on held-out runs, architectures, datasets, or task families. Observation fractions of 20%, 30%, 40%, 50%, 60%, and 70% of the available budget will characterize how prediction quality changes with evidence. These fractions are planned settings rather than completed experiments.

The benchmark will include fixed-epoch training, validation-based early stopping with tuned patience, and suitable learning-curve predictors. Hyperband/ASHA will be assessed under comparable configuration-search budgets, recognizing that multi-configuration resource allocation differs from stopping a single run. Baseline tuning will use the same development partitions and will be reported.

Method	Decision mechanism	Primary outcomes
Fixed budget	Predetermined training duration	Performance and cost
Early stopping	Validation trend and patience	Performance and cost
Curve extrapolation	Forecast from a partial curve	Prediction, performance, cost
Hyperband / ASHA	Allocation across configurations	Search performance and cost
ATI	Trajectory-based meta-prediction	Prediction, performance, cost

Table 1. Planned benchmark methods and outcomes.

5.2 Outcome measures

Epoch prediction will be assessed using absolute and relative error:

$$\mathrm{OEPE} = |\hat{E}^* - E^*|; \quad \mathrm{RPE} = |\hat{E}^* - E^*| / E^*. \quad (4)$$

Validation regret provides an offline diagnostic, $\Delta P_{val} = P_{val}(E^*) - P_{val}(\hat{E}^*)$. Deployed controller performance will instead use its actually retained checkpoint. Final test performance will be reported separately, without using test results to select an epoch. This distinction prevents the retrospective reference from being presented as an online achievement.

$$\text{Savings} = (C_{baseline} - C_{ATI}) / C_{baseline} \times 100\%. \quad (5)$$

C_{ATI} includes target-model training, telemetry, feature computation, and controller inference. Meta-model training cost will be reported separately together with any amortization assumption. Epoch counts alone may not represent computational savings across architectures. Wall-clock or device-time measurements will be recorded under documented hardware conditions.

Figures 7 and 8 illustrate the planned prediction-error and compute–performance analyses.

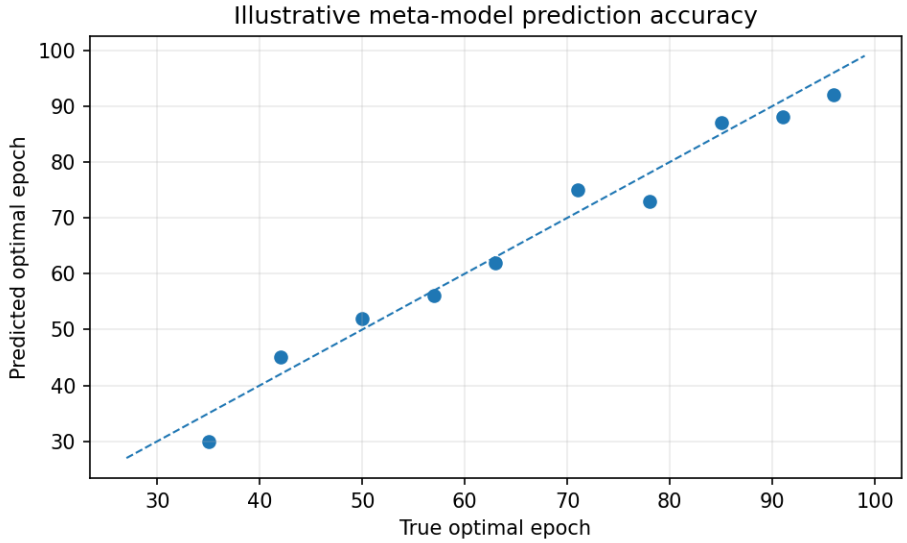


Figure 7. Predicted versus reference optimal epochs. Illustrative; not experimental results.

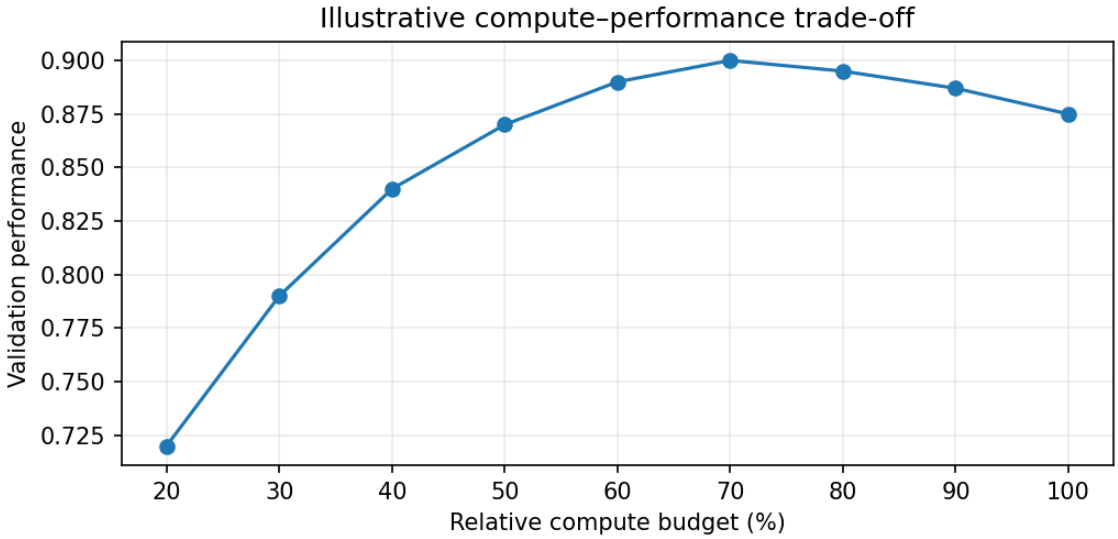


Figure 8. Compute–performance trade-off. Illustrative; not experimental results.

5.3 Ablation and statistical analysis

Ablations will compare metrics alone with temporal derivatives; inclusion and exclusion of the generalization gap and gradient features; short and long prefixes; tree-based and temporal predictors; and within-family versus cross-family evaluation. These comparisons are intended to identify which signals contribute beyond baseline validation behavior.

Multiple independent target-model seeds will be evaluated. Results will include distributions, means, standard deviations, medians, and confidence intervals where appropriate. Comparisons will be paired by target task and run. Correlated prefixes will not be counted as independent experiments. The main decision criterion is a reduction in total computation while keeping performance degradation below a prespecified application-dependent tolerance ε.

6. Limitations and Research Status

A noisy validation maximum may be unstable, and repeated development decisions can overfit the validation set. Distribution shift across architectures, tasks, optimization regimes, and budgets may invalidate a predictor. Late improvements, scheduler changes, and non-monotonic learning curves can also cause premature stopping. Predictive uncertainty therefore requires empirical assessment rather than being inferred from a point estimate.

The proposal does not report a collected meta-dataset, fitted ATI predictor, or measured compute savings. Figures 1–8 describe the intended analyses; they are not experimental observations. Future results must be derived from recorded runs and accompanied by the benchmark protocol, uncertainty estimates, and computational accounting.

7. Reproducibility and Implementation Plan

The implementation will separate experiment configuration, telemetry collection, feature computation, meta-dataset construction, prediction, controller operation, and evaluation. Archived outputs will include training logs, checkpoints, split manifests, software versions, and plotting scripts. A paired training demonstration may supplement the benchmark, but visual behavior alone will not establish predictive effectiveness.

Potential extensions include interval prediction, forecasting future validation performance, joint duration–hyperparameter optimization, online intervention, reinforcement-learning controllers, and energy accounting. Each extension requires its own evaluation and is outside the initial effectiveness claim.

8. Conclusion

ATI proposes learning a relationship between partial training trajectories and validation-optimal training duration. The research will test whether this relationship transfers to held-out regimes and whether it supports useful stopping decisions after accounting for overhead and performance loss. Comparative experiments, leakage-resistant splits, ablation studies, and independent final evaluation are required before drawing conclusions about effectiveness.

References

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